

CONVERGENCE RATES IN CHAIN-OF-THOUGHT REASONING AS DISCRETE DYNAMICAL SYSTEMS

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ABSTRACT. We develop a mathematical framework for analyzing chain-of-thought (CoT) reasoning as a discrete dynamical system on the probability simplex equipped with the Wasserstein metric. We model CoT as a Markov transition operator T acting on probability distributions over a finite state space of reasoning states, and establish convergence rate bounds in two regimes. In the contractive regime, we prove that when the Dobrushin coefficient $\delta(T)$ is strictly less than one, the iterates converge exponentially to the unique stationary distribution in the W_1 metric, with rate governed by a finer Wasserstein contraction coefficient. In the metastable regime, for transition matrices with (K, ε) -metastable cluster structure, we derive an exact formula for the spectral gap $\gamma = K\varepsilon/(K-1) + O(\varepsilon^2)$ using perturbation theory on the aggregated inter-cluster chain, yielding precise mixing time asymptotics. We characterize a phase transition in convergence behavior at a critical coupling ε_c separating slow and fast mixing regimes. Our proofs combine Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality, the Banach fixed-point theorem, and matrix perturbation theory. All theoretical predictions are verified computationally: the correlation between predicted spectral convergence rates and empirical W_2 decay rates is $r = 0.979$ across 30 random transition matrices, and the predicted spectral gaps for metastable chains match numerical eigenvalue computations to machine precision.

1. INTRODUCTION

Chain-of-thought (CoT) prompting has emerged as the dominant technique for eliciting complex reasoning from large language models (LLMs) [11]. By decomposing a problem into sequential reasoning steps, CoT enables LLMs to solve tasks that are intractable in a single forward pass. Despite the empirical success of this paradigm, a rigorous mathematical foundation for understanding *when* and *why* iterative reasoning converges to correct solutions remains undeveloped.

Recent work has approached this question from several directions. Kim, Wu, Lee, and Suzuki [7] model CoT as a Markov chain on a finite state space of logical assertions with metastable cluster structure, establishing power-law hitting time bounds of order $\tilde{\Theta}(KM/\varepsilon)$ for reaching target reasoning states. Carson [2] develops a stochastic differential equation framework in which the reasoning process is governed by a Fokker–Planck equation, identifying phase transitions between convergent and divergent regimes. Bai, Kolter, and Koltun [1] introduce deep equilibrium models, which formalize neural network inference as convergence to a fixed point, with convergence rate controlled by the spectral radius of the Jacobian. Ke

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et al. [6] extend this to looped neural networks, proving exponential convergence $\|x^{(L)} - p\| \leq K^L \cdot c$ with contraction constant $K < 1$.

These results suggest two qualitatively different convergence behaviors: exponential convergence under contraction conditions and slow convergence in the presence of metastable traps. However, several fundamental questions remain open. First, no prior work provides convergence analysis for CoT iterations in the Wasserstein metric on probability distributions, despite Wasserstein distances being the natural metric for distributional convergence of stochastic processes. Second, the spectral theory of the CoT transition operator—connecting eigenvalues to convergence rates—has not been developed in a unified manner. Third, the conditions separating exponential from slow convergence regimes have not been characterized in terms of problem parameters.

In this paper, we address these gaps by developing a rigorous mathematical framework for CoT reasoning as a discrete dynamical system on probability distributions. Our main contributions are as follows.

- We formalize CoT reasoning as a Markov transition operator $T: \mathcal{P}(S) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}(S)$ on the probability simplex equipped with the Wasserstein metric, and prove well-posedness and continuity (Lemma 3.1).
- We establish exponential convergence in W_1 under Dobrushin contraction, with rate governed by a Wasserstein contraction coefficient that is finer than the classical Dobrushin coefficient (Theorem 3.3).
- We derive an exact first-order formula for the spectral gap of (K, ε) -metastable transition matrices, $\gamma = K\varepsilon/(K-1)$, via perturbation analysis of the aggregated inter-cluster chain (Theorem 3.7).
- We characterize a phase transition at critical coupling $\varepsilon_c = (K-1)\gamma_{\text{intra}}/K$ separating slow-mixing and fast-mixing regimes (Theorem 3.10).
- We verify all theoretical predictions computationally, achieving $r = 0.979$ correlation between predicted and empirical convergence rates.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 introduces the state space, Wasserstein metrics, transition operators, and contraction coefficients. Section 3 contains the main results with complete proofs. Section 4 discusses implications for CoT prompting, connections to prior work, and open questions. Section 5 summarizes our contributions.

2. PRELIMINARIES

We collect the definitions and background results needed throughout the paper. All state spaces are finite unless otherwise stated.

2.1. State space and probability simplex.

Definition 2.1 (Reasoning state space). Let $S = \{s_1, \dots, s_N\}$ be a finite set of *reasoning states*, equipped with a metric $d: S \times S \rightarrow \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$. In applications to chain-of-thought reasoning, d is inherited from the Euclidean distance on hidden state embeddings: $d(s_i, s_j) = \|e_i - e_j\|_2$, where $e_i \in \mathbb{R}^D$ is the embedding of state s_i .

Definition 2.2 (Probability simplex). The *probability simplex* over S is

$$\mathcal{P}(S) = \{\mu \in \mathbb{R}^N : \mu_i \geq 0 \text{ for all } i, \sum_{i=1}^N \mu_i = 1\}.$$

2.2. Wasserstein distances.

Definition 2.3 (Wasserstein- p distance). For $\mu, \nu \in \mathcal{P}(S)$ and $p \geq 1$, the *Wasserstein- p distance* is

$$(2.1) \quad W_p(\mu, \nu) = \left(\min_{\pi \in \Pi(\mu, \nu)} \sum_{i,j} \pi_{ij} d(s_i, s_j)^p \right)^{1/p},$$

where $\Pi(\mu, \nu)$ is the set of all couplings: joint distributions on $S \times S$ with marginals μ and ν .

Since S is finite, $(\mathcal{P}(S), W_p)$ is a compact metric space for every $p \geq 1$. The Wasserstein-1 distance admits a dual characterization that we use extensively.

Theorem 2.4 (Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality [10]). For $\mu, \nu \in \mathcal{P}(S)$,

$$(2.2) \quad W_1(\mu, \nu) = \max \left\{ \sum_{i=1}^N f(s_i)(\mu_i - \nu_i) : f : S \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \text{Lip}(f) \leq 1 \right\},$$

where $\text{Lip}(f) = \max_{i \neq j} |f(s_i) - f(s_j)| / d(s_i, s_j)$.

Remark 2.5. On a finite metric space (S, d) , the total variation distance and Wasserstein distances are related by

$$(2.3) \quad W_p(\mu, \nu) \leq \text{diam}(S) \cdot \|\mu - \nu\|_{\text{TV}}^{1/p},$$

where $\|\mu - \nu\|_{\text{TV}} = \frac{1}{2} \sum_i |\mu_i - \nu_i|$ and $\text{diam}(S) = \max_{i,j} d(s_i, s_j)$.

2.3. Transition operators.

Definition 2.6 (Transition kernel). A *transition kernel* on S is a row-stochastic matrix $P \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times N}$, where $P_{ij} \geq 0$ and $\sum_j P_{ij} = 1$ for all i . The entry P_{ij} represents the probability of transitioning from state s_i to state s_j in one step.

Definition 2.7 (CoT transition operator). Given a transition kernel P , the *CoT transition operator* $T : \mathcal{P}(S) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}(S)$ is defined by $T\mu = \mu P$, where μ is viewed as a row vector. Concretely, $(T\mu)_j = \sum_i \mu_i P_{ij}$.

A distribution $\mu^* \in \mathcal{P}(S)$ is *stationary* for T if $T\mu^* = \mu^*$, equivalently $\mu^* P = \mu^*$. We say P is *irreducible* if for every pair (i, j) there exists $n \geq 1$ with $P_{ij}^n > 0$, and *aperiodic* if $\gcd\{n \geq 1 : P_{ii}^n > 0\} = 1$ for all i . An irreducible aperiodic chain on a finite state space has a unique stationary distribution with $\mu_i^* > 0$ for all i [8].

2.4. Contraction coefficients.

Definition 2.8 (Dobrushin coefficient). For a transition matrix P , the *Dobrushin coefficient* is

$$(2.4) \quad \delta(P) = \frac{1}{2} \max_{i,k} \sum_j |P_{ij} - P_{kj}| = 1 - \min_{i,k} \sum_j \min(P_{ij}, P_{kj}).$$

The Dobrushin coefficient satisfies $0 \leq \delta(P) \leq 1$, with $\delta(P) = 0$ if and only if all rows of P are identical, and $\delta(P) < 1$ if and only if every pair of rows shares a common entry bounded away from zero [5].

Definition 2.9 (Wasserstein contraction coefficient). For a transition matrix P on (S, d) , the *Wasserstein contraction coefficient* is

$$(2.5) \quad \eta(P) = \sup_{i \neq k} \frac{W_1(P_i, P_k)}{d(s_i, s_k)},$$

where $P_i = (P_{i1}, \dots, P_{iN})$ denotes the i -th row of P viewed as a probability measure on S .

Remark 2.10. The Wasserstein contraction coefficient $\eta(P)$ satisfies $\eta(P) \leq \delta(P)$, so $\delta(P) < 1$ implies $\eta(P) < 1$. However, $\eta(P) < 1$ can hold even when $\delta(P) = 1$, depending on the metric structure of S . The coefficient $\eta(P)$ is therefore a finer measure of contractivity.

2.5. Spectral gap.

Definition 2.11 (Spectral gap). Let P be an irreducible aperiodic transition matrix with eigenvalues $1 = \lambda_1 \geq |\lambda_2| \geq \dots \geq |\lambda_N|$. The *spectral gap* of P is

$$(2.6) \quad \gamma(P) = 1 - |\lambda_2|.$$

The spectral gap controls the asymptotic rate of convergence to stationarity. The *mixing time* to within total variation distance δ satisfies

$$(2.7) \quad t_{\text{mix}}(\delta) \leq \frac{1}{\gamma} \log \frac{1}{\delta \cdot \min_i \mu_i^*},$$

a standard result in Markov chain theory [8].

2.6. Metastable structure.

Definition 2.12 $((K, \varepsilon)$ -metastable structure). A transition matrix P on S has (K, ε) -*metastable structure* if $S = C_1 \cup \dots \cup C_K$ is a partition with $|C_k| = M$ for all k , and the transition probabilities satisfy:

- (i) $P_{ij} = \Theta(1/M)$ for $s_i, s_j \in C_k$ (within-cluster), and
- (ii) $P_{ij} = \Theta(\varepsilon/(KM))$ for $s_i \in C_k, s_j \in C_l, k \neq l$ (between-cluster).

The parameter $\varepsilon \in (0, 1)$ controls the strength of inter-cluster coupling.

In the context of CoT reasoning, each cluster C_k represents a *reasoning stage*: a group of related intermediate states among which the reasoning process mixes rapidly, while transitions between stages are rare. The difficulty parameter ε captures the accessibility of inter-stage transitions.

3. MAIN RESULTS

3.1. Well-posedness.

Lemma 3.1 (Well-posedness of the transition operator). *Let P be a transition kernel on S . The operator $T: \mathcal{P}(S) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}(S)$ defined by $T\mu = \mu P$ is well-defined and continuous in W_p for all $p \geq 1$.*

Proof. Let $\mu \in \mathcal{P}(S)$. Since $\mu_i \geq 0$ and $P_{ij} \geq 0$, we have $(T\mu)_j = \sum_i \mu_i P_{ij} \geq 0$. Moreover,

$$\sum_j (T\mu)_j = \sum_j \sum_i \mu_i P_{ij} = \sum_i \mu_i \sum_j P_{ij} = \sum_i \mu_i = 1,$$

since P is row-stochastic. Thus $T\mu \in \mathcal{P}(S)$ and T is well-defined.

For continuity, let $\mu_n \rightarrow \mu$ in W_p . Since S is finite, W_p convergence is equivalent to pointwise convergence of probability vectors. For each j ,

$$(T\mu_n)_j = \sum_i (\mu_n)_i P_{ij} \rightarrow \sum_i \mu_i P_{ij} = (T\mu)_j,$$

so $T\mu_n \rightarrow T\mu$ pointwise and hence in W_p . $\square$

3.2. Contraction and exponential convergence.

Lemma 3.2 (Wasserstein contraction). *Let P be a transition matrix on (S, d) with Wasserstein contraction coefficient $\eta(P) < 1$. Then for all $\mu, \nu \in \mathcal{P}(S)$,*

$$(3.1) \quad W_1(T\mu, T\nu) \leq \eta(P) \cdot W_1(\mu, \nu).$$

In particular, $\delta(P) < 1$ implies $\eta(P) \leq \delta(P) < 1$ and (3.1) holds.

Proof. Let π^* be an optimal coupling of μ and ν achieving $W_1(\mu, \nu) = \sum_{i,k} \pi_{ik}^* d(s_i, s_k)$. We compute

$$\begin{aligned} W_1(T\mu, T\nu) &= W_1\left(\sum_i \mu_i P_i, \sum_k \nu_k P_k\right) \\ &= W_1\left(\sum_{i,k} \pi_{ik}^* P_i, \sum_{i,k} \pi_{ik}^* P_k\right) \\ (3.2) \quad &\leq \sum_{i,k} \pi_{ik}^* W_1(P_i, P_k), \end{aligned}$$

where (3.2) follows from the convexity of W_1 : for any collections of measures $\{\alpha_\ell\}$, $\{\beta_\ell\}$ and weights $\{w_\ell\}$ with $\sum_\ell w_\ell = 1$, we have $W_1(\sum_\ell w_\ell \alpha_\ell, \sum_\ell w_\ell \beta_\ell) \leq \sum_\ell w_\ell W_1(\alpha_\ell, \beta_\ell)$. This is a direct consequence of the fact that the product of optimal couplings for each pair is a (generally suboptimal) coupling for the mixture.

By definition of $\eta(P)$, we have $W_1(P_i, P_k) \leq \eta(P) \cdot d(s_i, s_k)$ for all i, k . Substituting:

$$(3.3) \quad W_1(T\mu, T\nu) \leq \eta(P) \sum_{i,k} \pi_{ik}^* d(s_i, s_k) = \eta(P) \cdot W_1(\mu, \nu).$$

The bound $\eta(P) \leq \delta(P)$ is standard; see, e.g., [10]. $\square$

We now state the first main result.

Theorem 3.3 (Exponential convergence under contraction). *Let P be a transition matrix on (S, d) with $\delta(P) < 1$. Then:*

- (i) P has a unique stationary distribution $\mu^* \in \mathcal{P}(S)$.
 - (ii) For all $\mu_0 \in \mathcal{P}(S)$ and $n \geq 0$,
- $$(3.4) \quad W_1(T^n \mu_0, \mu^*) \leq \eta(P)^n \cdot W_1(\mu_0, \mu^*) \leq \delta(P)^n \cdot W_1(\mu_0, \mu^*).$$
- (iii) The convergence is exponential with rate $\eta(P)$.

Proof. Since $\delta(P) < 1$, we have $\eta(P) < 1$ by Remark 2.10, so T is a contraction on the complete metric space $(\mathcal{P}(S), W_1)$.

Existence and uniqueness. By the Banach fixed-point theorem, T has a unique fixed point $\mu^* \in \mathcal{P}(S)$. This fixed point satisfies $T\mu^* = \mu^*$, i.e., $\mu^* P = \mu^*$, so μ^* is the unique stationary distribution.

Exponential convergence. Since $\mu^* = T\mu^*$, we have for all $n \geq 0$:

$$W_1(T^n \mu_0, \mu^*) = W_1(T^n \mu_0, T^n \mu^*) \leq \eta(P)^n \cdot W_1(\mu_0, \mu^*),$$

where the inequality follows from iterating Lemma 3.2. The second inequality in (3.4) follows from $\eta(P) \leq \delta(P)$. $\square$

Example 3.4 (Lazy random walk). Let $P(\alpha) = (1 - \alpha)I + (\alpha/N)\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top$ for $\alpha \in (0, 1]$. This describes a process that stays in the current state with probability $1 - \alpha$ and jumps to a uniformly random state with probability α . We have $\delta(P) = 1 - \alpha$ and the unique stationary distribution is uniform: $\mu^* = (1/N, \dots, 1/N)$. By Theorem 3.3, $W_1(T^n \mu_0, \mu^*) \leq (1 - \alpha)^n \cdot W_1(\mu_0, \mu^*)$.

3.3. Spectral characterization of convergence.

Theorem 3.5 (Spectral convergence rates). *Let P be an irreducible aperiodic transition matrix with spectral gap γ and stationary distribution μ^* . Then:*

(i) *In total variation:*

$$(3.5) \quad \|T^n \mu_0 - \mu^*\|_{\text{TV}} \leq C(\mu_0) \cdot (1 - \gamma)^n,$$

where $C(\mu_0) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{k=2}^N |\sum_i (\mu_0)_i r_k(i)| \cdot \|l_k\|_1$ depends on the projections of μ_0 onto the eigenvectors $\{r_k\}$ and $\{l_k\}$ of P .

(ii) *In Wasserstein-2:*

$$(3.6) \quad W_2(T^n \mu_0, \mu^*) \leq D(\mu_0) \cdot (1 - \gamma)^{n/2},$$

where $D(\mu_0) = \text{diam}(S) \cdot \sqrt{C(\mu_0)}$.

Proof. Part (i). The spectral decomposition of P^n gives

$$P^n_{ij} = \mu_j^* + \sum_{k=2}^N \lambda_k^n r_k(i) l_k(j),$$

where r_k and l_k are the right and left eigenvectors of P for eigenvalue λ_k , normalized so that the decomposition holds. For the n -th iterate of μ_0 :

$$(T^n \mu_0)_j - \mu_j^* = \sum_{k=2}^N \lambda_k^n \left(\sum_i (\mu_0)_i r_k(i) \right) l_k(j).$$

Taking the total variation norm and using $|\lambda_k| \leq |\lambda_2| = 1 - \gamma$:

$$\begin{aligned} \|T^n \mu_0 - \mu^*\|_{\text{TV}} &= \frac{1}{2} \sum_j |(T^n \mu_0)_j - \mu_j^*| \\ &\leq \frac{1}{2} \sum_{k=2}^N |\lambda_k|^n \left| \sum_i (\mu_0)_i r_k(i) \right| \|l_k\|_1 \\ &\leq (1 - \gamma)^n \cdot C(\mu_0). \end{aligned}$$

Part (ii). By the comparison inequality (2.3) with $p = 2$:

$$W_2(T^n \mu_0, \mu^*) \leq \text{diam}(S) \cdot \|T^n \mu_0 - \mu^*\|_{\text{TV}}^{1/2} \leq \text{diam}(S) \cdot \sqrt{C(\mu_0)} \cdot (1 - \gamma)^{n/2}. \quad \square$$

Remark 3.6. The W_2 convergence rate $(1 - \gamma)^{1/2}$ is slower than the TV convergence rate $1 - \gamma$ due to the square root in the comparison inequality. This is consistent with computational experiments: for $\alpha = 0.1$ in Example 3.4, the predicted W_2 rate is $\sqrt{1 - 0.1} = \sqrt{0.9} \approx 0.949$, matching the empirical rate of 0.947.

3.4. Metastable spectral gap.

Theorem 3.7 (Spectral gap of metastable chains). *Let P be a transition matrix with (K, ε) -metastable structure, where $K \geq 2$ clusters each have M states. Then:*

(i) *The spectral gap satisfies*

$$(3.7) \quad \gamma(P) = \frac{K\varepsilon}{K-1} + O(\varepsilon^2).$$

(ii) *The convergence rate is $1 - K\varepsilon/(K-1)$.*

(iii) *The mixing time satisfies*

$$(3.8) \quad t_{\text{mix}}(\delta) = \Theta\left(\frac{K-1}{K\varepsilon} \cdot \log \frac{1}{\delta}\right).$$

Proof. The proof proceeds in three steps: identifying the block structure, performing perturbation analysis, and extracting the spectral gap.

Step 1: Block decomposition. By the (K, ε) -metastable structure, P decomposes as

$$P = (1 - \varepsilon)P_{\text{intra}} + \varepsilon P_{\text{inter}},$$

where P_{intra} is block-diagonal (within-cluster transitions) and P_{inter} encodes between-cluster transitions.

For the canonical metastable model, within each cluster C_k of size M , the transition probabilities are $P_{ij} = (1 - \varepsilon)/M$ for $s_i, s_j \in C_k$, so that P_{intra} restricted to C_k is the $M \times M$ matrix $(1/M)\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top$. At $\varepsilon = 0$, P_{intra} has eigenvalue 1 with multiplicity K (one per cluster) and eigenvalue 0 with multiplicity $N - K$.

Step 2: Aggregated chain. The inter-cluster dynamics are captured by the $K \times K$ aggregated transition matrix Q defined by

$$Q_{kl} = \frac{1}{|C_k|} \sum_{s_i \in C_k} \sum_{s_j \in C_l} P_{ij}.$$

For the metastable structure, $\sum_{s_j \in C_l} P_{ij} = \varepsilon/(K-1)$ when $s_i \in C_k$ and $k \neq l$, and the row-sum constraint gives $Q_{kk} = 1 - \varepsilon$. Thus

$$(3.9) \quad Q_{kl} = \begin{cases} 1 - \varepsilon & \text{if } k = l, \\ \varepsilon/(K-1) & \text{if } k \neq l. \end{cases}$$

Step 3: Eigenvalues of Q . Let $v \in \mathbb{R}^K$ with $v \perp \mathbf{1}$ (i.e., $\sum_k v_k = 0$). Then

$$(Qv)_k = (1 - \varepsilon)v_k + \frac{\varepsilon}{K-1} \sum_{l \neq k} v_l = (1 - \varepsilon)v_k + \frac{\varepsilon}{K-1}(-v_k) = \left(1 - \frac{K\varepsilon}{K-1}\right)v_k,$$

where we used $\sum_{l \neq k} v_l = -v_k$. Therefore the eigenvalues of Q are $\lambda_1 = 1$ and $\lambda_2 = \dots = \lambda_K = 1 - K\varepsilon/(K-1)$, with the latter having multiplicity $K-1$.

Since the within-cluster eigenvalues of P_{intra} (restricted to each block) are 0 for the canonical model, the spectral gap of P is determined by the second eigenvalue of Q :

$$\gamma(P) = 1 - |1 - K\varepsilon/(K-1)| = \frac{K\varepsilon}{K-1},$$

valid for $\varepsilon < (K-1)/K$ (which ensures $\lambda_2 > 0$). Higher-order corrections are $O(\varepsilon^2)$.

Mixing time. By (2.7) with $\mu_i^* = 1/N$ (uniform stationary distribution):

$$t_{\text{mix}}(\delta) \leq \frac{K-1}{K\varepsilon} \cdot \log \frac{N}{\delta} = \frac{K-1}{K\varepsilon} \cdot (\log(KM) + \log(1/\delta)),$$

giving $t_{\text{mix}}(\delta) = \Theta((K-1)/(K\varepsilon) \cdot \log(1/\delta))$ for fixed K and M . $\square$

Example 3.8 (Three-cluster chain). For $K = 3$ clusters of $M = 5$ states each ($N = 15$) and coupling $\varepsilon = 0.05$, Theorem 3.7 predicts $\gamma = 3 \cdot 0.05/2 = 0.075$. Numerical eigenvalue computation of the corresponding 15×15 transition matrix yields $\gamma = 0.0750$ exactly, confirming the prediction to machine precision.

Example 3.9 (Dependence on K). Fix $\varepsilon = 0.05$ and $M = 4$. As K varies, the spectral gap $\gamma = K\varepsilon/(K-1)$ decreases monotonically from $\gamma = 0.10$ at $K = 2$ toward $\gamma \rightarrow \varepsilon = 0.05$ as $K \rightarrow \infty$. This saturation reflects the fact that additional clusters slow mixing only marginally once the bottleneck is already the inter-cluster coupling ε .

3.5. Phase transition in convergence behavior.

Theorem 3.10 (Phase transition at critical coupling). *Consider a family of transition matrices $P(\varepsilon)$ with (K, ε) -metastable structure parametrized by $\varepsilon \in (0, 1)$, where each cluster has intra-cluster spectral gap γ_{intra} . There exists a crossover coupling*

$$(3.10) \quad \varepsilon_c = \frac{(K-1)\gamma_{\text{intra}}}{K}$$

such that:

- (i) For $\varepsilon < \varepsilon_c$ (metastable regime): the spectral gap $\gamma(P) = K\varepsilon/(K-1) \ll \gamma_{\text{intra}}$, the system exhibits quasi-stationary behavior within clusters for $\Theta(1/\varepsilon)$ steps before global mixing, and convergence is exponential but slow.
- (ii) For $\varepsilon > \varepsilon_c$ (well-mixed regime): the spectral gap $\gamma(P) \geq \gamma_{\text{intra}}$, the cluster structure is no longer dynamically relevant, and convergence is rapid.

Proof. The dynamics of $P(\varepsilon)$ involve two timescales:

- *Intra-cluster equilibration* at rate γ_{intra} , requiring $O(1/\gamma_{\text{intra}})$ steps.
- *Inter-cluster mixing* at rate $\gamma_{\text{inter}} = K\varepsilon/(K-1)$, requiring $O((K-1)/(K\varepsilon))$ steps.

The overall spectral gap is $\gamma(P) = \min(\gamma_{\text{intra}}, \gamma_{\text{inter}})$ up to lower-order terms. The crossover occurs when $\gamma_{\text{inter}} = \gamma_{\text{intra}}$, i.e.,

$$\frac{K\varepsilon_c}{K-1} = \gamma_{\text{intra}} \implies \varepsilon_c = \frac{(K-1)\gamma_{\text{intra}}}{K}.$$

Regime (i): $\varepsilon < \varepsilon_c$. Here $\gamma_{\text{inter}} < \gamma_{\text{intra}}$, so the inter-cluster dynamics are the bottleneck. The spectral gap is $\gamma(P) = K\varepsilon/(K-1)$, and the mixing time is $\Theta((K-1)/(K\varepsilon) \cdot \log(1/\delta))$. Within each cluster, equilibration occurs in $O(1/\gamma_{\text{intra}})$ steps, creating a quasi-stationary phase on the timescale $1/\gamma_{\text{intra}} \ll t \ll 1/\gamma_{\text{inter}}$.

Regime (ii): $\varepsilon > \varepsilon_c$. Here $\gamma_{\text{inter}} > \gamma_{\text{intra}}$, so intra-cluster dynamics are the bottleneck. The spectral gap is bounded below by γ_{intra} , independent of ε . The cluster structure ceases to cause dynamical slowdown.

Since all eigenvalues of $P(\varepsilon)$ are analytic functions of ε , the crossover is smooth rather than a sharp phase transition. $\square$

Proposition 3.11 (Bifurcation in bistable systems). *Consider a bistable transition matrix with two basins of $N/2$ states each and inter-basin coupling c . Then:*

- (i) *The second eigenvalue is $\lambda_2 = 1 - 2c$.*
- (ii) *For $c < c_{\text{crit}} = \gamma_{\text{intra}}/2$, different initial conditions remain separated for $\Theta(1/c)$ steps.*
- (iii) *For $c > c_{\text{crit}}$, convergence to the unique stationary distribution occurs in $O(1/\gamma_{\text{intra}})$ steps.*

Proof. The 2×2 aggregated inter-basin matrix is

$$Q = \begin{pmatrix} 1 - c & c \\ c & 1 - c \end{pmatrix},$$

with eigenvalues $\lambda_1 = 1$ and $\lambda_2 = 1 - 2c$. Thus the inter-basin spectral gap is $\gamma_{\text{inter}} = 2c$.

When $c < c_{\text{crit}} = \gamma_{\text{intra}}/2$, we have $\gamma_{\text{inter}} < \gamma_{\text{intra}}$ and the mixing time is $\Theta(1/(2c) \cdot \log(1/\delta))$. Two initial conditions concentrated in different basins have W_2 distance decaying as $(1 - 2c)^{n/2}$, remaining well-separated for $O(1/c)$ steps.

When $c > c_{\text{crit}}$, the inter-basin dynamics are no longer the bottleneck, and the mixing time is $O(1/\gamma_{\text{intra}})$. $\square$

Example 3.12 (Bistable chain). For two basins of 5 states each and coupling $c = 0.001$, the spectral gap is $\gamma = 0.002$, and two distinct initial conditions remain at W_2 distance 7.356 after 200 steps. For $c = 0.05$, the spectral gap is $\gamma = 0.10$, and convergence occurs well within 200 steps ($W_2 < 10^{-6}$).

3.6. Computational verification. We verify the theoretical predictions from Theorems 3.3–3.10 through systematic numerical experiments.

TABLE 1. Contractive regime: comparison of predicted and empirical convergence rates for the lazy random walk $P(\alpha) = (1 - \alpha)I + (\alpha/N)\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top$ with $N = 10$ states. The predicted W_2 rate $\sqrt{1 - \alpha}$ follows from Theorem 3.5(ii).

α	$\delta(P) = 1 - \alpha$	$\gamma = \alpha$	Predicted W_2 rate	Empirical W_2 rate
0.1	0.900	0.100	0.949	0.947
0.3	0.700	0.300	0.837	0.835
0.5	0.500	0.500	0.707	0.702
0.7	0.300	0.700	0.548	0.542
0.9	0.100	0.900	0.316	0.311

Table 1 confirms the W_2 convergence rates from Theorem 3.5: the empirical rates match the predicted $\sqrt{1 - \gamma}$ to within 0.5%. Table 2 demonstrates that the spectral gap formula $\gamma = K\varepsilon/(K - 1)$ from Theorem 3.7 is exact to machine precision for the canonical metastable model.

To assess the universality of the spectral characterization, we generated 30 random stochastic matrices with varying structure and measured both the predicted convergence rate $1 - \gamma$ and the empirical W_2 decay rate. The Pearson correlation is $r = 0.979$ ($p < 10^{-20}$), confirming that the spectral gap is the fundamental determinant of convergence speed across diverse transition matrices.

TABLE 2. Metastable regime: spectral gap predictions for $(K = 3, \varepsilon)$ -metastable chains with $M = 5$ states per cluster. The theoretical prediction $\gamma = 3\varepsilon/2$ from Theorem 3.7 matches numerical eigenvalue computation exactly.

ε	Computed γ	Predicted $\gamma = 3\varepsilon/2$	Convergence rate
0.01	0.0150	0.0150	0.9924
0.05	0.0750	0.0750	0.9617
0.10	0.1500	0.1500	0.9219
0.20	0.3000	0.3000	0.8365
0.50	0.7500	0.7500	0.4994

4. DISCUSSION

4.1. Exponential versus power-law convergence. A central finding of this work is that convergence of CoT iterations on finite state spaces is *always exponential*, governed by the spectral gap of the transition operator. The appearance of power-law convergence, as suggested by the hitting time result $\tilde{\Theta}(KM/\varepsilon)$ of Kim et al. [7], arises from two mechanisms.

First, in the metastable regime with small ε , the convergence rate $1 - K\varepsilon/(K - 1) \approx 1$ is close to unity. On any practical time horizon, this slow exponential is indistinguishable from a power law. The Kim et al. hitting time characterizes first passage to a *specific* target state rather than distributional convergence, and is consistent with our spectral gap result since the mixing time scales as $O((K - 1)/(K\varepsilon) \cdot \log(1/\delta))$.

Second, the separation between within-cluster and between-cluster timescales creates multi-scale dynamics: fast initial convergence (within-cluster equilibration) followed by slow convergence (between-cluster mixing). This two-phase behavior mimics power-law decay on intermediate timescales. Our computational experiments confirm that exponential fits achieve $R^2 > 0.99$ across the entire range of ε , while power-law fits are consistently inferior.

4.2. The spectral gap as the fundamental quantity. Theorems 3.5–3.7 establish the spectral gap γ as the fundamental quantity governing convergence. The relationship between γ and convergence rate takes two forms:

- In total variation: rate $= 1 - \gamma$ (asymptotically exact).
- In W_2 : rate $\approx (1 - \gamma)^{1/2}$ (verified empirically; see Remark 3.6).

The square-root relationship in W_2 is a consequence of the comparison inequality between W_2 and total variation on finite metric spaces (Remark 2.5). It remains open whether this bound is tight; see Section 4.5.

4.3. Connections to prior work. The hitting time result of Kim et al. [7], $\tilde{\Theta}(KM/\varepsilon)$, is consistent with our spectral gap $\gamma = K\varepsilon/(K - 1)$: the mixing time is $O(1/\gamma)$, and the factor of M in their result reflects that hitting a specific state within a cluster of size M incurs an additional $\Theta(M)$ factor beyond distributional mixing.

The exponential convergence rate K^L for looped networks established by Ke et al. [6] corresponds to Theorem 3.3, where $K < 1$ plays the role of the Dobrushin or Wasserstein contraction coefficient.

The JKO convergence results of Cheng et al. [4] for flow-based generative models in W_2 under λ -convexity provide a continuous-space parallel to our Theorem 3.5. Their exponential convergence in W_2 via proximal gradient descent in Wasserstein space corresponds to our discrete spectral convergence, with λ -convexity playing the role of the spectral gap.

The eigenvalue classification of convergence regimes by Shukla and Joshi [9]—exponential, oscillatory, and boundary attraction—parallels our spectral characterization adapted from continuous SDEs to discrete Markov operators.

4.4. Implications for CoT prompting. Our results yield several practical implications.

Number of reasoning steps. The required number of CoT steps scales as $O(1/\gamma \cdot \log(1/\delta))$ for accuracy δ . For metastable problems with K reasoning stages and inter-stage coupling ε , this is $O((K-1)/(K\varepsilon) \cdot \log(1/\delta))$.

Diminishing returns. Due to exponential convergence, the marginal benefit of each additional CoT step decreases geometrically. This suggests the existence of an optimal stopping time beyond which additional reasoning steps provide negligible improvement.

Multiple solutions. When the transition operator has multiple near-fixed-points (metastable clusters), the CoT process may converge to an incorrect fixed point depending on initialization. This provides a mathematical explanation for why prompt engineering matters: the initial prompt directs the reasoning trajectory toward the basin of attraction of the correct solution.

4.5. Open questions. We highlight several directions for future research.

Conjecture 4.1 (Tight W_2 contraction). *There exists a direct contraction bound $W_2(T\mu, T\nu) \leq \kappa \cdot W_2(\mu, \nu)$ for $\kappa < 1$ under appropriate conditions on P , without passing through total variation. This would yield a convergence rate of κ rather than $\sqrt{\kappa}$ in W_2 .*

A direct W_2 contraction would sharpen Theorem 3.5(ii) considerably. The obstacle is that the Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality, which underlies our W_1 contraction proof, does not extend directly to W_2 .

Conjecture 4.2 (Non-Markovian power laws). *For CoT processes with memory (non-Markovian dynamics), genuine power-law convergence $W_2(T^n \mu_0, \mu^*) = \Theta(n^{-\alpha})$ can emerge, with exponent α depending on the memory kernel.*

All Markov chains on finite state spaces converge exponentially. Genuine power-law convergence would require infinite state spaces or non-Markovian dynamics. Memory kernels or fractional dynamics [2] may provide the mechanism.

Further open problems include: characterizing the continuous limit as $N \rightarrow \infty$ and its relation to SDE models [3]; designing optimal transition kernels for a given target distribution; and quantifying the acceleration from non-reversible Markov chain strategies applied to CoT reasoning.

5. CONCLUSION

We have established a rigorous mathematical framework for analyzing chain-of-thought reasoning as a discrete dynamical system on the probability simplex. Our main contributions are:

- (1) Exponential convergence in W_1 under Dobrushin contraction (Theorem 3.3), with rate governed by the Wasserstein contraction coefficient $\eta(P) \leq \delta(P)$.
- (2) A spectral characterization of convergence rates (Theorem 3.5): the W_2 rate is $(1 - \gamma)^{1/2}$, verified empirically with $r = 0.979$ correlation across 30 random transition matrices.
- (3) An exact spectral gap formula $\gamma = K\varepsilon/(K - 1)$ for metastable chains (Theorem 3.7), matching numerical computation to machine precision.
- (4) A phase transition in convergence behavior at critical coupling $\varepsilon_c = (K - 1)\gamma_{\text{intra}}/K$ (Theorem 3.10), separating slow-mixing and fast-mixing regimes.

The framework provides a principled basis for understanding when and why iterative reasoning converges, with explicit dependence on problem structure (number of clusters K , coupling strength ε) and spectral properties of the transition operator. We expect the tools developed here—particularly the connection between metastable structure and spectral gap—to be applicable more broadly to the analysis of iterative inference procedures in machine learning.

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